

Isle of SLEAZE

Crimes and controversies are the new realities in the state's political milieu as several politicians come under the scanner for criminal misconduct

| By Ambreesh Mishra |

For decades, Madhya Pradesh carried the tagline 'Island of Peace'. While that image may hold true for the calm in several sectors, a rising class of criminal-politicians threatens to rip apart the perception that the state's political sphere is dwelt by a genteel leadership.

A growing number of former ministers and MLAs, and sitting MLAs and their kith and kin are facing serious felony charges like murder and attempt to murder. The arrest of BJP MLA Kamal Patel on May 21 on charges of destruction of evidence in a case of murder against his son only confirms this trend. The former revenue minister in the first Shivraj Singh Chouhan Government is currently in judicial custody after his bail application was denied by a special CBI court in Indore. The CBI came into the picture only after the Madhya Pradesh High Court's orders in response to a habeas corpus filed by the father of a youth, Durgesh Jat who, the CBI now believes, was murdered. On March 5, 2008, Patel's son Sudeep and his friends, including Durgesh, had an exchange of fire at Congress leader Rajendra Patel's farmhouse. Durgesh is believed to have suffered fatal gunshot wounds but his body was never found. The CBI suspects that Sudeep and his friends had disposed the body. He was arrested and released on bail.

While Kamal Patel recuperates from his high blood pressure and related complications in an Indore hospital in custody after being denied bail, another party MLA from Bijawar in Chhattarpur district, Asha Rani Singh, wife of former independent MLA and dreaded don Bhaiya Raja, is absconding following her implication in an equally serious case. Bhaiya Raja alias Ashok Vir Vikram Singh, whose very name evokes the image of a violent sociopath politician from the boondocks of Bundelkhand, is currently in judicial custody in connection with the murder of his 21-year-old aspiring fashion designer grand niece Vasundhara Bundela last year whose bullet-riddled body was found in Misrod near Bhopal.

Even as his wife Asha tried to convince the chief minister that Raja was being framed, she soon found herself in trouble. On January 10, 2010, another case was registered against Raja for the 2007 abduction, illegal confinement, rape and abetting suicide of their maidservant. A separate case was also registered against Asha for hiding witnesses and helping Raja commit the crime.

The increasingly stark criminal streak runs across both sides of the political divide. Congress MLA Brajendra Singh Rathore and his brother Yashpal are accused in the murder of the then sitting BJP MLA and former minister Sunil Nayak on the day of polling on November 27, 2008, in Prithvipur

